

DECODED EXPLAINED

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A Healthy Tax: The Government Must Act to Tax Foods High in Fat, Sugar, and Salt

A healthy tax

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India, which has a long history of addressing the challenges of undernutrition, has to pivot to attack the curious phenomenon of over-nutrition that evolving lifestyles have now laid at its door. The recent National Family Health Survey data showed that in India, while stunting and undernutrition continue to be cause for concern, despite some gains, the sharp rise in adult overweight and obesity, besides diet-related metabolic conditions, cannot be ignored any more. Two unrelated developments have advanced the question of unhealthy diets in very pointed suggestions that would nudge consumers to make the right choices. First, a Parliamentary Standing Committee has recommended mandatory front-of-pack nutrition labelling indicating whether packaged food products are high in sugar, and second, a national consortium has advised the government to levy a health tax on high fat, salt and sugar foods, and enforce stricter regulations on their advertisements. The Standing Committee on Consumer Affairs, Food and Public Distribution also made a recommendation to include the sugar content in baby foods, attacking the excess sugar consumption issue right where it begins. The consortium on adolescent nutrition, which goes by the practical name Let's Fix Our Food, is led by the Indian Council of Medical Research-National Institute of Nutrition (ICMR-NIN), and comprising several other prominent institutions in India and abroad, has recommended that the government ensure a healthier school food environment, stricter regulation of marketing of unhealthy food, and front-of-pack nutrition labelling. These efforts will be among the steps to tackle the rising burden of obesity and diet-related non communicable diseases that require a comprehensive strategy helmed by the government.

According to the World Health Organization, since 2017, at least 133 countries have increased or introduced a new health tax. A "junk food law" came into force in Colombia in 2023, to tackle the high consumption of packaged foods. An additional tax on such foods began at 10%, rose to 15% the next year and touched 20% the subsequent year. Norway, Hungary, Denmark, Bermuda, Dominica, St. Vincent and the Grenadines, and the Navajo Nation (U.S.), have also specifically implemented taxes on unprocessed sugar and sugar-added foods. With the ICMR-NIN report indicating that over 17 million children and adolescents are affected by obesity, and that this number can cross 27 million by 2030, there cannot be a better time to act on these suggestions that will go a long way in educating the consumer to make healthy food choices.

A Healthy Tax: The Government Must Act to Tax Foods High in Fat, Sugar, and Salt

● The Context

Recent National Family Health Survey data showed that while stunting and undernutrition continue to be a cause for concern, the sharp rise in adult overweight and obesity, besides diet-related metabolic conditions, cannot be ignored any more

● Two Key Developments

- First, a Parliamentary Standing Committee has recommended mandatory front-of-pack nutrition labelling indicating whether packaged food products are high in sugar, and has also recommended including sugar content disclosure in baby foods

- Second, a national consortium called Let's Fix Our Food, led by the ICMR-National Institute of Nutrition, has advised the government to levy a health tax on high fat, salt, and sugar foods, and enforce stricter regulations on their advertisements

● Global Precedent

- According to the WHO, since 2017, at least 133 countries have increased or introduced a new health tax; a 'junk food law' came into force in Colombia in 2023, with an additional tax on packaged foods beginning at 10%, rising to 15% the next year, and touching 20% the subsequent year

- Norway, Hungary, Denmark, Bermuda, Dominica, St. Vincent and the Grenadines, and the Navajo Nation in the US have also specifically implemented taxes on unprocessed sugar and sugar-added foods

Cabinet Approves Scheme to Promote 'Floating' Solar Plants

Cabinet approves scheme to promote 'floating' solar plants

Jacob Koshy
NEW DELHI

The Union Cabinet on Friday approved the Pradhan Mantri Surya Sarovar Yojana, a ₹5,070-crore scheme aimed at accelerating floating solar power by providing central financial assistance of up to ₹1 crore per MW for projects installed on reservoirs and other water bodies.

The programme targets 5,000 MW of floating solar capacity by 2030-31.

The scheme, to be implemented by the Solar Energy Corporation of India, comes at a time when India has about 0.7 GW of installed floating solar capacity despite an estimated potential of 102 GW.

Projects receiving support under the scheme will have to include battery energy storage equivalent to at least two hours, amounting to 10,000 MWh across the programme, to help States meet peak demand and reduce the curtailment of renewable power during periods of excess generation.

India's flagship project, the Omkareshwar floating solar park, located on the Narmada in Madhya Pradesh's Khandwa district is the country's largest at 278 MW, with plans to scale to 600 MW output. However,



The programme targets 5,000 MW of floating solar capacity by 2030-31.

it doesn't have onsite battery storage.

Officials said the financial support was intended to "nudge" the industry to develop an alternative stream of solar capacity. Solar development in India has remained concentrated in Rajasthan and Gujarat because of their vast tracts of inexpensive land and high solar radiation.

Reservoir-based projects are expected to "diversify" installations, particularly in States with large water bodies but limited land availability.

The policy is also designed to address two of the biggest constraints facing ground-mounted solar projects: acquiring large contiguous parcels of land and the rising costs associated with rehabilitation and resettlement.

Cabinet Approves Scheme to Promote 'Floating' Solar Plants

Pradhan Mantri Surya Sarovar Yojana (PM-SSY)

The PM-SSY is a Central Sector Scheme to promote the development of Floating Solar Photovoltaic (FSPV) Projects integrated with Energy Storage Systems (ESS).

The scheme has a financial allocation of Rs. 5,070 crore to develop 5,000 MW of FSPV capacity between FY 2026-27 and FY 2030-31.

To ensure grid stability, the projects are required to include co-located Energy Storage Systems with a minimum storage capacity of two hours (totaling 10,000 MWh across the scheme).

Land-Neutral Technology: Unlike ground-mounted solar, floating solar eliminates competition for agricultural land and habitation, making it ideal for large-scale deployment.

The Omkareshwar Floating Solar Park on the Narmada River (Madhya Pradesh) is India's largest operational project at 278 MW, with a planned expansion to 600 MW. It is the largest floating solar park in India.

S. Sreejith, Suresh Rajpurohit Get Promoted to DGP Rank

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The Hindu Bureau
THIRUVANANTHAPURAM

The State government promoted Suresh Rajpurohit and S. Sreejith to the rank of Director General of Police (DGP) on Friday. The promotions were implemented shortly after the retirement of Director General of Kerala Fire and Rescue Services Nitin Agrawal.

Notably, Mr. Rajpurohit's promotion has been made on a proforma basis since he is presently away on Central deputation. Mr. Sreejith, who is presently posted as Director General of Prisons and Correctional Services, will continue to hold the position.

Home department sources indicated that more transfers are in the offing to fill the post of Managing Director of the Ker-



S. Sreejith and Suresh Rajpurohit.

ala State Beverages Corporation, which has remained vacant for nearly a week since the suspension of Additional Director General of Police M.R. Ajith Kumar, and the position of the Director General of Kerala Fire and Rescue Services.

Speaking at his farewell parade held at the SAP ground in Thiruvananthapuram, Mr. Agrawal

called Kerala Police a model force for the country. He said the experience and training he received in the State had greatly contributed to his professional career and enabled him to serve more effectively in different assignments.

A 1989-batch IPS officer, Mr. Agrawal is the recipient of several prestigious honours, including the President's Police Medal.

S. Sreejith, Suresh Rajpurohit Get Promoted to DGP Rank

The Director General of Police (DGPs) are the highest-ranking police officers in states and union territories.

Supreme Court Directives in Prakash Singh Case (2006)

DGPs must be appointed through a merit-based and transparent process.

They must have a minimum tenure of at least two years, to prevent arbitrary transfers influenced by political pressures.

State governments are required to consult the Union Public Service Commission (UPSC) before appointing a DGP.

The Court rejected the practice of appointing "Acting DGPs" to ensure stable and permanent leadership.

Process

Sending List of Eligible Officers to UPSC : State governments must send a list of eligible IPS officers to the UPSC for consideration.

Eligibility Criteria : Officers must have a minimum of 25 years of service.

Should hold the rank of Additional Director General (ADG) or equivalent.

UPSC's Role : Selection committee, chaired by the UPSC Chairman, evaluates the candidates.

The UPSC prepares a panel of three officers deemed most suitable for the DGP position.

Shortlisted names are sent back to the respective state government.

The state government appoint one of the officers as the DGP.

Spain's PM Blames Trafficking Gangs as 60,000 Cross Into Ceuta in a Day

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At least 57 migrants died during the crossing attempt; Sanchez calls the breach a violation of Spain's territorial integrity; Spain's Interior Ministry says half of the migrants had already returned to Morocco; EU leader terms it 'unacceptable'

Associated Press
CEUTA

About 60,000 migrants crossed from Morocco into Spain's tiny Ceuta territory in the past 24 hours, Ceuta's President said on Friday, a figure that is equivalent to 70% of the population of the city in North Africa. At least 57 migrants died on the journey.

But roughly half of the people who made the crossing soon made their way back voluntarily, the Spanish government said, after the sudden arrival of so many migrants triggered chaos and a humanitarian crisis.



Massive influx: Members of Moroccan security forces gather at the site of clashes on the Morocco-Spain border, on Friday. AFP

"The situation that Ceuta is going through is absolutely unsustainable," Juan Jesus Vivas told the media.

Spain's Prime Minister Pedro Sanchez visited Ceuta and condemned the

breach which he described as "a violation of Spain's territorial integrity".

Mr. Sanchez blamed human smugglers for the crisis, saying they "deceive so many young people, and

ultimately lead many of them to their deaths – whether in the ocean or, as in this case, at Spain's border in the city of Ceuta".

Spain's Interior Ministry, which had initially refused to share estimates from the border, released its own figures shortly after Mr. Vivas spoke, estimating that some 50,000 people had crossed from Morocco since Thursday.

The border crisis boiled over with security forces clashing with migrants on the Moroccan side of the border. Video footage of the border early on Friday showed hundreds of migrants gathered on a hill overlooking Ceuta being dispersed with tear gas by

Moroccan forces, while others continued to swim to the Spanish territory.

Rachid Sbihi, who leads a local workers association representing Civil Guard officers, described the situation as a "serious humanitarian crisis," saying thousands of migrants, including unaccompanied children, were left sleeping in parks and on pavements, while others roamed the streets.

European Commission President Ursula von der Leyen said the "images coming from Ceuta are unacceptable".

"We cannot allow anyone to come to our Union without abiding by our rules," she said on Friday.



Spain's PM Blames Trafficking Gangs as 60,000 Cross Into Ceuta in a Day

Spain

Spain is located on the Iberian Peninsula in southwestern Europe

Bordering Countries:

It shares its borders with Portugal (to the west),

France and Andorra (to the northeast), and

The British Overseas Territory of Gibraltar (to the south).

Morocco: Via the autonomous cities of Ceuta and Melilla on the North African coast

Maritime borders: It is bounded by the Mediterranean Sea (to the southeast and east), the Bay of Biscay (to the north), and the Atlantic Ocean (to the northwest and southwest).

Capital City: Madrid.

The Pyrenees Mountains form a natural barrier between Spain and France.

The Meseta Central is a vast interior plateau, dominating the central part of Spain.

Archipelagos: Includes the Balearic Islands in the Mediterranean and the volcanic Canary Islands in the Atlantic.



Spain's PM Blames Trafficking Gangs as 60,000 Cross Into Ceuta in a Day

Catalonia (Catalunya) Separatist Movement

The Catalonia (Catalunya) separatist movement is a political movement in northeastern Spain seeking greater autonomy or independence based on Catalonia's distinct language, culture, and historical identity. The movement gained momentum due to perceived fiscal imbalances, demands for self-governance, and memories of repression under the Franco dictatorship (1939–1975). Its defining moment came in 2017, when the Catalan government held an independence referendum that was declared unconstitutional by Spain, leading Madrid to impose direct rule under Article 155. Unlike a classical insurgency, the movement has remained largely non-violent, pursuing its objectives through elections, legal challenges, and mass public demonstrations.



Spain's PM Blames Trafficking Gangs as 60,000 Cross Into Ceuta in a Day

Basque Country Insurgency

The Basque Country insurgency was a violent ethno-nationalist separatist movement led mainly by ETA (Euskadi Ta Askatasuna), which sought an independent Basque homeland spanning northern Spain and parts of southwestern France. Emerging in 1959 during the Franco dictatorship, ETA employed bombings, assassinations, kidnappings, and other militant tactics for decades, resulting in more than 800 deaths. Following Spain's democratic transition, greater regional autonomy, effective counter-terrorism cooperation between Spain and France, and declining public support for violence, ETA declared a permanent ceasefire in 2011 and formally dissolved in 2018, marking the end of one of Europe's longest-running separatist insurgencies.



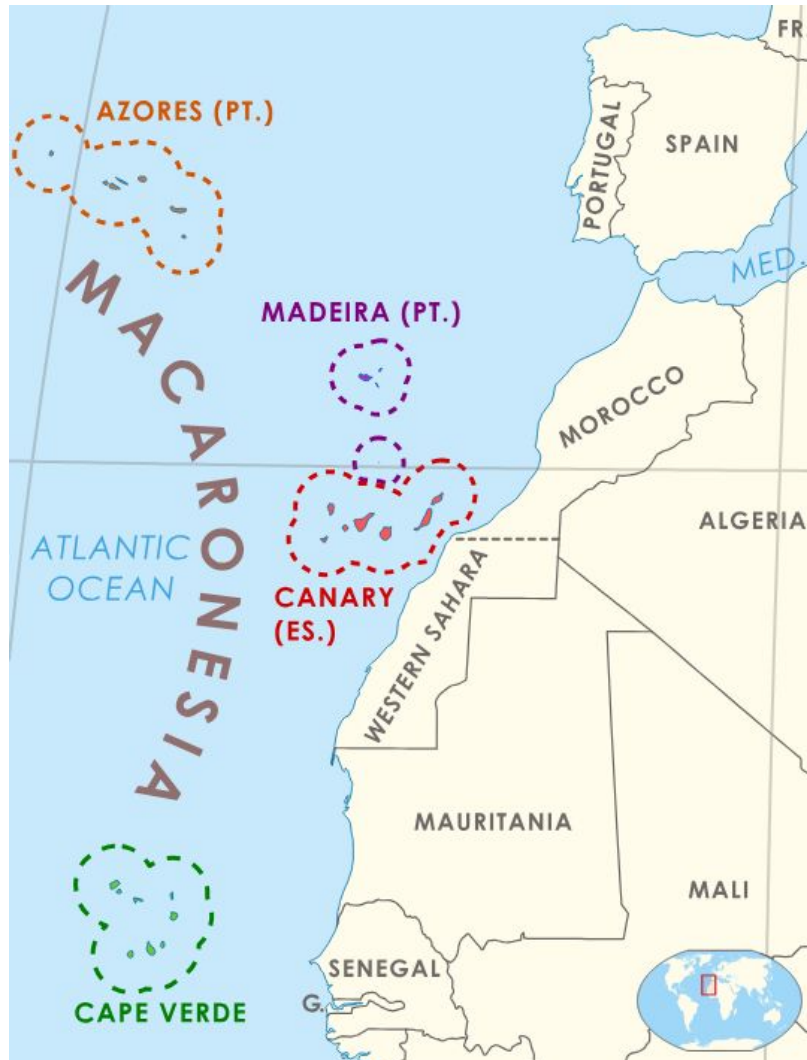
Spain's PM Blames Trafficking Gangs as 60,000 Cross Into Ceuta in a Day

Canary Islands

Canary Islands are an archipelago located off the northwest coast of Africa in the Macaronesia region of the North Atlantic Ocean. Read more about Canary Islands, Location, Area, Capital, Latest News.



Spain's PM Blames Trafficking Gangs as 60,000 Cross Into Ceuta in a Day



Macronesia consists of

Azores (Portugal),

Madeira (Portugal),

Canary Islands (Spain)

Cape Verde (Independent Country

Spain's PM Blames Trafficking Gangs as 60,000 Cross Into Ceuta in a Day

UPSC Prelims 2018 Question:

Consider the following pairs:

Sl. No.	Regions sometimes mentioned in the news		Country
1	Catalonia	:	Spain
2	Crimea	:	Hungary
3	Mindanao	:	Phillipines
4	Oromia	:	Nigeria

Which of the pair given above are correctly matched?

1. 1, 2 and 3

2. 3 and 4 only

3. 1 and 3 only

4. 2 and 4 only

Consider the following pairs:

	<i>Region often mentioned in the news</i>	<i>Country</i>
1	Anatolia	Turkey
2	Amhara	Ethiopia
3	Cabo Delgado	Spain
4	Catalonia	Italy

How many pairs given above are correctly matched?

This question was previously asked in

UPSC Civil Services Exam Official
2022 Prelims General Studies...

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1. Only one pair

2. Only two pairs

3. Only three pairs

4. All four pairs

Where are the Balearic Islands located?

- a. Mediterranean Sea
- b. Black Sea
- c. Baltic Sea
- d. North Sea

UPSC Prelims PYQ 2005

UK PM Burnham signals support for written Constitution

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Agence France-Presse

LONDON

Britain's new Prime Minister Andy Burnham has signalled his support for a written Constitution for the U.K., which, unlike most countries, does not have one authoritative document and is governed by a patchwork of statutes, common law judgments, and treaties.

Since entering office just two weeks ago, the former mayor of Greater Manchester has made devolution of power to regional authorities a focus of his administration.

"In the end, I think it does start to point towards a new constitutional settle-



Andy Burnham

ment," Mr. Burnham said of his devolution plans on the weekend.

Calling for a "new clear set of principles about how this country should be run", Mr. Burnham said there was a need for a written Constitution – something he has called for before he was Prime Minister.

The state against its students, lessons to remember

The state against its students, lessons to remember

In July 26, 1876, 150 years ago almost to the day, Surendranath Banerjee founded the Indian Association in Calcutta. Its first great agitation was, at its core, a student grievance. The colonial government had lowered the maximum age for the Indian Civil Service examination from 21 to 19, a change that quietly shut young Indians out of the highest offices open to them. The state treated the complaint as an administrative footnote. Banerjee treated it as a constitutional question, toured the country, and turned the anger of examination-going youth into the first genuinely pan-Indian political mobilisation. The Raj never recovered the loyalty of the generation it dismissed.

Fifty years ago, in the winter and monsoon of 1976, two states on two continents were teaching the opposite lesson in real time. On June 16, schoolchildren in Soweto, South Africa, who marched against the imposition of Afrikaans as the medium of instruction were met with live ammunition; hundreds died in the weeks that followed. In India, the Emergency had already emptied the campuses by other means: student unions stood suspended, and activists of every persuasion sat in jail under the Maintenance of Internal Security Act (MISA). Pretoria used bullets, New Delhi used preventive detention, and both were confident they had restored order. Within a decade and a half, the generation of Soweto had made apartheid ungovernable, and the generation of the Emergency had produced much of India's post-1977 political leadership. Order purchased through the suppression of the young turned out to be the most expensive commodity either state ever bought.

The pattern repeats again

This July, the streets around Parliament and Jantar Mantar have supplied the third panel of the triptych. What began as an online satire has become one of the largest student mobilisations in years, built on grievances that are neither manufactured nor abstract: a leaked National Eligibility cum Entrance Test (Undergraduate), or NEET-UG, paper that forced the cancellation of an undergraduate medical examination taken by over 20 lakh aspirants, and an on-screen marking controversy that left thousands of school students in limbo. So far, the state's response has followed the familiar pattern of barricades, tear gas, a baton charge that injured more than 100 students during the march on Parliament, and rhetoric from the highest levels of the establishment comparing protesters to vermin.



Shashank Pandey

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From 1876 to 2026, student grievances expose failures of governance

History suggests three lessons that the state would do well to learn before the pattern completes itself. **Lesson one: force does not disperse a genuine grievance, it organises it.** The Soweto uprising did not begin as a revolution. It began as a march by schoolchildren over the language of instruction. It was the shooting that made it a revolution. Every image of a fallen student became a recruitment poster, exile camps filled with teenagers who had left the country in the months after June 1976. The regime's own commission later conceded that the police response, not the original grievance, had transformed a protest into an insurrection.

The mechanism is not South African, it is universal. When the state answers a specific, bounded demand with generalised violence, it converts a policy dispute into a question of dignity, and dignity disputes do not settle. The students who returned to Jantar Mantar the morning after the lathi charge, and said so to every camera available, were following a script written in Soweto and in a hundred places since. A government that reads their return as defiance to be broken, rather than as evidence that force has already failed, is preparing its own sequel.

The politics of disrespect

Lesson two: contempt delegitimises the state faster than it delegitimises the students. The colonial government's error in 1876 was not primarily one of policy. It was one of register. By treating the civil service age question as beneath serious engagement, it told an entire educated generation that their aspirations had no standing before the state. Banerjee understood that the insult was more mobilising than the injury, and the Indian Association was built on that understanding.

The instinct to belittle is alive today. When constitutional functionaries such as the Chief Justice of India reach for the vocabulary of pest control to describe a section of youth, they repeat the Raj's mistake with less excuse. Dehumanising language aimed at the young does not shrink a movement but hands the movement its identity, its symbols and its moral high ground in a single gesture. The protesters outside Parliament this week did not have to manufacture the charge that the state holds them in contempt. The state made the charge for them, on the record. A government serious about de-escalation would begin not with concessions but with a change of register by acknowledging, plainly and publicly, that the integrity of public examinations is a legitimate constitutional concern of every citizen who sits

for one, and that those raising it are stakeholders, not enemies.

Lesson three: protest is the symptom; blocked accountability is the disease. Students do not camp on pavements because they enjoy tear gas. They do so when every institutional channel for redress has been tried and found closed. The 1876 agitation arose because Indians had no representative forum in which the civil service rules could even be debated and the Association became the forum the constitution did not provide. The Emergency-era campuses went silent because the ordinary machinery of accountability, the courts, the press, the legislature, had been suspended; when it was restored in 1977, the verdict was unambiguous.

The Gen Z-led education reform movement has been explicit that it wants action rather than assurances: credible investigations, examination reform, and accountability for the institutional failures that preceded the leak. These are demands that a functioning system of parliamentary and regulatory oversight should have been capable of processing without a single barricade. The durable answer to this protest is therefore not a better crowd-control strategy but a stronger accountability architecture, wherein an examination authority enjoys genuine independence, evaluation and reevaluation are subject to statutory transparency, parliamentary committee scrutiny produces published findings, and consequences attach to officials rather than only to invigilators and middlemen. A state that builds those channels makes the street redundant. A state that refuses to build them makes the street inevitable.

Ensure genuine accountability

It is an accident of the calendar, but a useful one, that the July 2026 crackdown falls in the same week as the sesquicentenary of the Indian Association. The men who governed India in 1876 could not have imagined that a students' grievance about an examination would seed the movement that ended their rule. Public officials who governed India and South Africa in 1976 could not have imagined that the teenagers they jailed and shot would inherit their states. No government ever believes the pattern applies to itself. That is precisely how the pattern survives.

The young people at Jantar Mantar were not asking the state to surrender. They were asking it to be worthy of the examinations it conducts. On the evidence of a century and a half, the governments that listen to that request are the ones that last.

The state against its students, lessons to remember

The Indian Association was the first avowed nationalist organization founded in British India by Surendranath Banerjee and Ananda Mohan Bose in 1876

The Association attracted educated Indians and civic leaders from all parts of the country and became an important forum for India's aspirations for independence. It later merged with the Indian National Congress.

The reduction of age limit (1877) from 21 to 19 years for the candidates of the Indian Civil Service examination gave it an excellent opportunity to start an all India movement. Under the leadership of Surendranath Banerjee, the Association strongly protested against this unjust decision.

Analysing the SC's judgment on sex work

Analysing the SC's judgment on sex work

For more than three decades, sex workers have told governments and courts how anti-trafficking interventions cause profound harm including forced rescues, indefinite detention in “corrective homes”, separation from children and even threat to life. And for decades, these accounts were only acknowledged in fragments, and never in a comprehensive rights-based framework. That is what makes the Supreme Court's judgment of May 29, 2026, so significant.

Across nearly 300 pages, the court departs from many assumptions that have long shaped anti-trafficking discourse globally. It recognises that agency and vulnerability can coexist; rejects the conflation of migration with trafficking; affirms that constitutional rights do not disappear because society disapproves of sex work; holds that consenting adult sex workers cannot forcibly be rescued; and that any intervention must begin with an inquiry into consent. Invoking Article 142, the court gives these directions legal force.

But the judgment also exposes a paradox: it adopts arguments that have been painstakingly developed by sex workers but does not acknowledge the workers or their collectives (such as the National Network of Sex Workers among others). This is not only a question of credit; it reveals how even progressive jurisprudence can reproduce a hierarchy of knowledge in which those most affected by law remain its least recognised authors.

What the judgment assumes
The judgment places faith in institutions that have repeatedly failed the very people it seeks to protect. The court assumes that clearer legal standards will produce different institutional behaviour – that police officers will assess consent without prejudice, magistrates will suspend moral judgment, shelter homes will become rights-based



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Sex workers and their unions must move from the margins to the centre of implementation. They should draft guidelines, monitor compliance, shape police training, and establish standards for shelters

support services, and sex workers will have access to legal aid.

For many women, especially those from the Dalit and Adivasi communities, bureaucracy has never been a neutral system. Caste discrimination and economic marginalisation continue to shape everyday encounters with the state. One woman, wrongly labelled a trafficker after a raid, has spent seven years reporting every month to a police station while attending court hearings where, despite all this time, her statement has never even been recorded. “I go to court and sit outside. Then they call my name, and I go inside. But they don't ask me anything. They have not even recorded my statement yet!”

The top court rightly recognises caste as one of the structural conditions that can push women into sex work. But it stops there. Caste does not simply explain entry into the profession. It also structures every institution responsible for implementing this judgment. As one worker put it: “The state says that *acche din* (good days) will come. When will our *acche din* come? Everything is about money these days. Take any actor. They can kill but do not get arrested. Those who do not have money have to keep going to the court like me.” Her question exposes the judgment's central assumption: that the law is applied equally once rights are recognised. For many workers, the challenge is not only overcoming moral prejudice. It is navigating a legal and bureaucratic system that continues to be shaped by caste.

The judgment is also noticeably quieter about another source of violence: the anti-trafficking industry itself. The court recommends reforming shelter homes but does not examine the organisations that run them, the funding structures that sustain them, or the incentives that make carceral and forced rescue practices persist. The rescue industry is not solely a humanitarian project. It is sustained by a dense network of

civil society organisations that participate in forced raids, manage shelter homes, and exercise significant authority over the women confined within them.

One woman who experienced both prison and a government shelter offered a striking comparison. “Even after rescue, we are bound by the shelter. It is another form of bondage. It seems better to serve six months in jail and come out free than to stay in a shelter for an unknown time.” This account is not an exception. It exposes an uncomfortable reality that anti-trafficking discourse obscures: rescue can become another mechanism of control.

The road ahead

The top Court's recommendations are important. But for the judgment to fulfil its promise, three priorities stand out.

First, sex workers and their unions must move from the margins to the centre of implementation. They should draft guidelines, monitor compliance, shape police training, and establish standards for shelters. Second, the anti-trafficking NGO sector deserves scrutiny. Longstanding evidence suggests that some have become active participants in coercive rescue practices while operating with limited accountability to the communities they claim to serve. Their funding and legal immunity should no longer be taken for granted. Finally, the structural conditions identified by the court do not require new institutions to fix. India already possesses an extensive welfare architecture. The challenge is ensuring that sex workers can access it as rights-bearing citizens.

The Supreme Court has opened an important constitutional door. Whether it leads to meaningful change will depend on whether India's institutions can abandon decades of paternalism and begin treating sex workers as citizens whose choices deserve the same legal respect as anyone else's.

Analysing the SC's judgment on sex work

Supreme Court has recognised sex work as a “profession” and observed that its practitioners are entitled to dignity and equal protection under law.

Article 21 declares that no person shall be deprived of his life or personal liberty except according to procedure established by law. This right is available to both citizens and non-citizens.

Sex workers should not be “arrested or penalised or harassed or victimised” whenever there is a raid on any brothel, “since voluntary sex work is not illegal and only running the brothel is unlawful”.

Immoral Traffic (Prevention) Act, 1956 (ITPA):

Does not criminalise sex work per se, but penalises brothel-keeping, soliciting, and living off earnings of sex work

India Produces Smart scientists but is struggling to retain them

India produces smart scientists but is struggling to retain them

Research flourishes when ideas compete but suffers when people compete for proximity to power; many of India's laboratories continue to operate within rigid hierarchies that would appear strange in leading scientific institutions elsewhere in the world

Biju Dharmapalan

Recent reports of nearly 120 scientists resigning from the Indian Space Research Organisation (ISRO) have rightly raised concerns. The ISRO has been a symbol of India's scientific aspirations and such an exodus cannot be dismissed as an ordinary episode of employee turnover.

Resignations have occurred over the years but the scale of recent departures confronts us with the question: of why some of India's brighter scientific minds are electing to leave institutions millions dream of joining.

The phenomenon is not unique to ISRO. Similar stories have emerged from laboratories under the Council of Scientific and Industrial Research (CSIR), premier autonomous institutes, and several government-funded research organisations. Often these departures are hard to notice as part of a larger pattern because they occur one scientist at a time – yet together they point to a deeper issue deserving of national attention.

Real main reason

The most obvious explanation is salary but it is not sufficient. Scientists who have spent decades building their expertise and reputation rarely leave only because another organisation is offering a bigger paycheck. Many of those that are resigning are also in the latter half of their careers, and generally unwilling to risk financial and professional stability. No, what they want is something even greater: professional dignity, freedom of thought, and the freedom to work on their topics of choice.

Several researchers – many of whom are unwilling to go on record for fear of repercussions – in private characterise these institutions as places where bureaucratic power is increasing at the expense of that of science, and where it is becoming more risky to question authority. The tragedy is that while Indian science inherited world-class institutions, it also retained a colonial administrative mindset.

Research flourishes when ideas compete but suffers when people compete for proximity to power. Many of India's laboratories continue to operate within rigid hierarchies that would appear strange in leading scientific institutions elsewhere in the world. Young scientists often learn quickly that survival depends less on asking bold scientific questions than on understanding invisible administrative boundaries. In some institutions, even simple acts of professional equality are viewed as breaches of etiquette. Respect, instead of being earned through scholarship and mentorship, is demanded through designation.

A class system

In order to be creative, for example, a doctoral student should be able to



Representative image of the National Institute of Animal Biotechnology (NIAB) in Hyderabad. India is spending a historically unprecedented, but otherwise still insufficient, amount of money on scientific research. FILE PHOTO

challenge a senior scientist's hypothesis without fearing that his or her long-term career will be adversely affected. A young investigator should feel confident enough to question established ideas. The world's best research environments are the best because they allow just such interactions.

Attend an international scientific conference in Europe or the Americas and you will often witness something remarkably ordinary: Nobel laureates standing in the same canteen queue as graduate students, and young scholars openly questioning senior scientists during presentations. They are respectful – and the seniors know that – but that respect flows from intellectual contributions rather than via ceremonial protocols.

However, many Indian scientific gatherings continue to have a bureaucratic, rather than academic culture. Distinguished speakers receive VIP badges, exclusive dining arrangements, and special hospitality while students and junior participants are treated as an entirely different class. Such symbolism is not harmless: it reinforces a hierarchy that has little place in science. Science has never progressed because someone occupied a larger office or enjoyed a separate lunch. Let us foster the many little interactions; they could make a big difference.

Speaking up

Equally worryingly, scientists rarely speak openly about unhealthy technologies, cultures because the ecosystem is remarkably small. Today's reviewer may become tomorrow's selection committee member. Today's director may influence tomorrow's funding decision.

Several researchers – many of whom are unwilling to go on record for fear of repercussions – in private characterise some institutions as places where bureaucratic power is increasing at the expense of that of science

Occasionally, some disturbing information emerges, including allegations of harassment, vindictive administrative actions, and attempts to publicly discredit accomplished scientists. Whether every allegation withstands scrutiny is for due process to determine – but the recurring perception is immediately damaging.

As a result, many talented researchers are now moving to private research organisations, emerging deep-tech companies, universities abroad, and/or international collaborations where scientific autonomy has more room than administrative strictures. India's growing innovation ecosystem benefits from this movement to some extent but it is not a zero-sum: our national laboratories lose institutional memory and experienced mentors.

India is spending a historically unprecedented, but otherwise still insufficient, amount of money on scientific research. Excellent skills are now needed for new research missions, including those involving semiconductors, quantum technologies, artificial intelligence, biotechnology, and spaceflight. But whereas buildings can be built in a few months and, with adequate funds, sophisticated instruments can be bought, building an environment that

holds great scientists is a very long process, often taking decades.

Conscious effort

Today, India must increase administrative transparency in scientific institutions, and install robust systems to redress grievances concerning workplace harassment and mentoring-based leadership training to ensure a leadership free from command.

In parallel, we need a conscious effort to break free of the colonial bureaucracy that remains in the daily life of institutions. Respect should not disappear from scientific workplaces but it differs fundamentally from unquestioning deference.

India has repeatedly demonstrated that its scientists possess extraordinary capability. Our achievements in space exploration, vaccines, supercomputing, mathematics, biotechnology, and engineering stand as testimony to that talent. The challenge today is not producing brilliant scientists – our universities and institutions have figured that out. The challenge is to ensure those scientists can still flourish after they enter India's laboratories.

If we fail to reform workplace culture, the next generation may simply leave our public institutions. That will be an immeasurable loss. Science has always advanced through ideas that challenged power – not by power that silenced people or ideas.

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THE GIST

Recent reports of nearly 120 scientists resigning from the Indian Space Research Organisation (ISRO) have rightly raised concerns

Many talented researchers are now moving to private research organisations, emerging deep-tech companies, universities abroad, and/or international collaborations where scientific autonomy has more room than administrative strictures

India must increase administrative transparency in scientific institutions, and install robust systems to redress grievances concerning workplace harassment and mentoring-based leadership training

India Produces Smart scientists but is struggling to retain them

Brain Drain refers to the emigration of highly skilled and educated individuals from one country to another, usually in search of better opportunities.

In India engineers, doctors, scientists, IT professionals, and academics move to developed countries like the USA, UK, Canada, and Australia.

Between 2015 and 2022, 1.3 million Indians left the country, many of whom were highly educated professionals.

Top Destinations: The United States, Canada, and Europe remain top destinations for these skilled workers.

India Produces Smart scientists but is struggling to retain them

Why

Colonial Administrative Mindset: Research institutions often operate with rigid bureaucratic oversight where administrative authority overrides scientific merit and questioning leadership carries professional risks.

Hierarchical Workplace Culture: Respect is frequently demanded via official designations rather than earned through scientific mentorship and scholarship. Junior scientists and graduate students are often discouraged from challenging established hypotheses.

Institutional Symbolism and Class Division: Academic conferences and lab environments frequently reinforce class divides through VIP arrangements, badges, and separate dining facilities rather than fostering egalitarian scientific discourse.

Lack of Open Grievance Redressal: Small, interconnected scientific ecosystems make researchers hesitant to voice workplace concerns, fearing repercussions on peer reviews, committee selections, or future funding approvals.

Pull of External Opportunities: Experienced researchers are increasingly drawn toward private research organizations, deep-tech startups, global industry roles, and international research universities offering superior intellectual autonomy.

India Produces Smart scientists but is struggling to retain them

Impact of Losing Senior Talent:

Loss of Institutional Memory: Frequent resignations by experienced project leads erode decades of specialized domain knowledge required for complex national missions.

Disruption to Mentorship Pipelines: Senior researchers serve as essential mentors for early-career scientists; their departure weakens training for the next generation.

Risks to High-Stakes National Projects: Unplanned departures create short-term operational vulnerabilities in strategic sectors like spaceflight, quantum computing, AI, and semiconductors.

For doxxing victims in India, a patchwork of laws to navigate

For doxxing victims in India, a patchwork of laws to navigate

Vineet Bhatta
New Delhi, August 2

WOMEN WHO participated in the protests at Delhi's Jantar Mantar are finding themselves at the center of an online backlash.

Social media accounts have shared videos and photographs of a number of such women at the protests, and made public their personal details such as phone numbers and home addresses. This has resulted in instances of harassment, including rape and death threats. The act of publicly revealing private personal information to intimidate or shame someone is known as doxxing. Despite its severe real-world consequences, doxxing is not explicitly defined or penalised as a criminal offence under Indian law. Legal experts say that victims have to navigate a patchwork of existing statutes under the Bharatiya Nyaya Sanhita (BNS) and the Information Technology (IT) Act to find recourse.

Laws in India

The issue must be viewed in two parts, Supreme Court lawyer Shruati Narayan told *The Indian Express*. Dissemination of personal information, and subsequent threats or harassment based on that information, "The latter is easier to prosecute under criminal law."

If doxxing leads to someone monitoring a woman's internet use or trying to contact her repeatedly, it attracts Section 78 of the BNS, which deals with stalking. Rape and death threats fall under Section 351 of the BNS, which deals with criminal intimidation. If the victim is a minor, Section 12 of the Protection of Children from Sexual Offences Act is invoked. Supreme Court lawyer Prasanna S said that if the

• WHAT IS DOXXING?

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doxxing involves the publication of pictures that humiliate a woman, it can trigger Section 29 of the BNS — which punishes acts intended to insult the modesty of a woman" and those that "intrude upon the privacy of... a woman". If the published content relates to the violation of one's reputation, provisions for criminal defamation can be invoked, he added.

However, when it comes to the mere publication of personal data, the law is uncertain. Narayan explained that the act of doxxing itself is largely treated as a civil offence under the IT Act, rather than a criminal one, "unless intimate images are shared."

Section 66D of the IT Act criminalises the capturing or publishing of images of private body parts without consent. For general personal data, victims have to rely on Section 72A of the IT Act, which penalises the unauthorised disclosure of information, but this section primarily provides for a financial penalty of up to Rs 5 lakh, making it a civil wrong rather than a criminal offence.

Platform accountability

Victims can also hold social media platforms accountable. Under the IT (Intermediary Guidelines and Digital Media Ethics Code) Rules, 2021, platforms are legally obligated to make reasonable efforts to prevent users from hosting information "invasive of another's privacy including bodily privacy, insulting or harassing on the basis of gender."

The Rules mandate strict timelines for platforms to act. Intermediaries are required to acknowledge complaints within 24 hours and resolve them within seven days. For complaints regarding content that falls under specific severe categories — such as privacy invasions or harassment — platforms must resolve the issue within 36 hours.

If a platform fails to comply with these rules or ignores court orders, it risks losing its "safe harbour" protection — a legal immunity that shields tech companies from being prosecuted for what users post on their sites. In practice, however, "different platforms of course have varying levels of responsiveness and safety tools," Naraina Malhotra, Asia Pacific Policy Manager and Global Encryption Policy Lead at Access Now, an international digital rights organisation, told *The Indian Express*.

For immediate relief, lawyers advise victims to preserve all evidence, including screenshots and URLs of the abusive posts.

For doxxing victims in India, a patchwork of laws to navigate

Doxxing refers to the act of publicly revealing someone's private personal information to intimidate or shame them.

India does not have a dedicated law framework to prevent doxxing

Why are people turning to social media for childbirth advice

Why are people turning to social media for childbirth advice?

Social media platforms are monetising unscientific content promoting home births and free births without doctors; while many parents turn to these practices after traumatic hospital experiences, experts warn that unsafe online advice and lack of regulation can have fatal consequences

Sahana Venugopal

The story so far:

In late June, a Tamil Nadu woman, 32, died from a postpartum haemorrhage and other complications. According to the police, the woman died after a medically unassisted birth at home, where family members allegedly helped her by watching YouTube videos for guidance. She leaves behind both her newborn and an older daughter. According to the initial police reports, the couple had wanted a “natural delivery.”

Around the world, more people who want to give birth at home or without doctors and surgeries are going to Reddit, Instagram, and YouTube to both give and get medical guidance. This unvetted, high-risk content could cost the lives of more parents and newborns.

Is social media promoting childbirth without doctors?

Social media companies with millions of users – Google-owned YouTube and Meta-owned Instagram – are allowing content creators to share unscientific advice, as well as make money from videos that document and promote home births with only a midwife. On Reddit, most home birthing content is text-based but still poses risks.

For example, a home birth YouTube vlog posted in November 2025 with over 146,000 views showed the mother touting a “2-HOUR PAIN FREE HOME BIRTH!” in a small pool, as well as promoting a religious birthing course and app. The mother said she gave birth at 42 weeks, and claimed she experienced a “healthy,

supernatural labor”. The vlog claimed that the midwife “finally got there only a few minutes before the baby’s arrival” and that the family waited 90 seconds for the newborn’s first breath, which is far longer than the accepted standard.

Another “natural home birth” vlog that was documenting the mother’s labour ended with an emergency hospital delivery after meconium (the baby’s very sticky first faeces) was detected before birth, upping the risk of potential infection should the baby inhale this via the amniotic fluid (meconium aspiration).

“Not the outcome we hoped for, but grateful to the NHS for keeping me and baby safe,” stated the description of the mother’s video from September that had over 420,000 views.

Multiple similar home birth vlogs contained links to online storefronts and other social media channels, or promoted products, coupon codes and affiliate links. This allows home birthers to directly profit from their content and view counts. But monetising childbirth vlogs brings up ethical concerns as birth videos include footage of the naked newborn and/or the mother in an undressed and vulnerable state.

On Instagram, several free birth influencers claim that they are going through their pregnancies without any doctors’ appointments or ultrasound scans.

Other free or home birthers on Instagram recommended extending pregnancies well beyond 41 weeks (to avoid being induced at a hospital), even though such delays without medical clearance can increase the chances of a stillborn baby. Free birth influencers and

even some midwives online share frightening anecdotes about patient abuse, and push the false idea that women’s bodies are made to birth babies without outside help.

In Reddit’s Home Birth community, forum rules ban medical advice. However, this rule is openly flouted as people often ask sensitive medical questions, with other users’ answers presented as opinions or personal stories.

One pregnant user in the Reddit Home Birth community, for example, posted that they had multiple high blood pressure readings. They dismissed these readings and declined a hospital-recommended induction. Instead, they asked Reddit users about taking a specific oil. This Reddit poster also minimised the potential risks of that oil causing the baby to pass faeces (meconium) before birth.

The work of free birth influencers online has already led to fatal consequences in the offline world. Take the Free Birth Society movement – with 72,000 subscribers on YouTube and 134,000 followers on Instagram – that has been named in relation to multiple baby injuries and deaths around the world, per an investigation by *The Guardian*. The founder has continued to promote highly unscientific videos, as well as her business, on social media.

Unlike the health content shared online during the COVID-19 pandemic that came with compulsory medical disclaimers, home birthing videos on YouTube and Instagram lack formal warnings about the dangers of giving birth in one’s house (home birth) or without doctors present (free birth).

Why do people choose home births or free births?

There are valid reasons why these practices still exist. Many pregnant women on forums such as Reddit have posted about traumatising birthing experiences at hospitals, such as being ignored or assaulted by healthcare professionals, being pressured into caesarean deliveries, having surgeons cut them without warning, not being given adequate pain relief, and having their bodies and babies handled roughly.

For their part, home birthers portray their deliveries as being quiet, peaceful, luxurious, and even spiritual. Edited vlogs and curated clips on social media show the birthing parents being cared for by their partners, midwives, and other children for hours on end. Many are seen seated in a pool of warm water while surrounded by soft lights, nature, prayers, soothing music, snacks, and even photographers. In multiple such videos, rushing to the hospital to be induced or undergo a C-section is often framed as a catastrophe to be avoided until the very last minute. But when such practices are normalised, hospital doctors and nurses face increased pressure; instead of a monitored delivery, they are dealing with a medical emergency.

In truth, the popularity of free birthing and home birthing can be seen as a response to the failure of hospitals to give pregnant parents the standard of care that they require. But as influencers leverage both trauma and technology in order to promote life-threatening birthing practices on social media, what viewers must really see is the dangerous absence of regulation.

Thank You